



BEFORE

After the Union captures of New Orleans (see [The Fall of New Orleans](#)), Memphis (see [Action on the Mississippi River](#)), and Vicksburg (see [The Vicksburg Campaign](#)), the North controlled the Mississippi River, but the Confederates were still active in the river's hinterland.

CONFEDERATE COMMANDS

Southern forces held **most of Mississippi**—the state's black prairie region was an important granary, and **General Nathan Bedford Forrest's feared horsemen** roamed the pinewoods. West of the Mississippi River, Confederate General Kirby Smith was based in Shreveport, Louisiana. **General Sterling Price**, the victor at Wilson's Creek in 1861 (see [Missouri and Kentucky](#)), faced Union forces in southern Arkansas.

UNION STRATEGY

In his grand strategy for 1864, General Ulysses S. Grant planned for **General Sherman to advance on Atlanta**, leaving detachments in Tennessee to patrol his long supply lines against Forrest's raiders. Grant hoped that **General Nathaniel Banks** in New Orleans might advance on Mobile, Alabama. But President Lincoln wanted Banks, in conjunction with Admiral David D. Porter's river fleet, to attack **Shreveport via Louisiana's Red River**. He hoped to isolate Texas and thwart any Confederate alliance with the French in Mexico.

For Union general William T. Sherman, the Red River Campaign of March–May 1864 was one “damn blunder from beginning to end.” General Nathaniel Banks’s target was Shreveport, Louisiana, the Confederate headquarters of the Trans-Mississippi West, standing on the Red River, a tributary of the Mississippi. But he was routed by Richard Taylor at the Battle of Mansfield on April 8. Although Banks rallied the next day to fend off Taylor at Pleasant Hill, Union reinforcements from Arkansas were also defeated, spelling doom for the expedition. On the campaign’s naval front, Admiral David D. Porter’s gunboats were stranded upriver by low water. They only escaped after the herculean efforts of the 10,000 men who built wing dams, which stemmed the current enough to refloat the ships.